

INTREPID DUSK™

VOLUME 1

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JEREMY MOHLER for helping me to get launched creating this graphic novel series. My late father, Ken Gregerson who was a linguist, helped me translate English into ancient Akkadian cuneiform for this volume. Prema and Priya Gregerson, who inspired me and without whom I could not have done this. They ground me in ways I can't put into words, so that I can travel to other worlds and always find my way home. Others to thank are: Chris Skaggs for his encouragement and support, Sanjay Patel and Tehreem Siddiqui for help on early photo reference that Roberto incorporated into character designs, Mike Cooper for his useful feedback, Derek Koehl for early brainstorming and recently Nolan Lynch for his editing which was very helpful right before this went to be printed. Also a special thanks to Sharon Marta who has helped to architect the design on both web and print for this project. Any mistakes or errors in this volume are mine alone to own.

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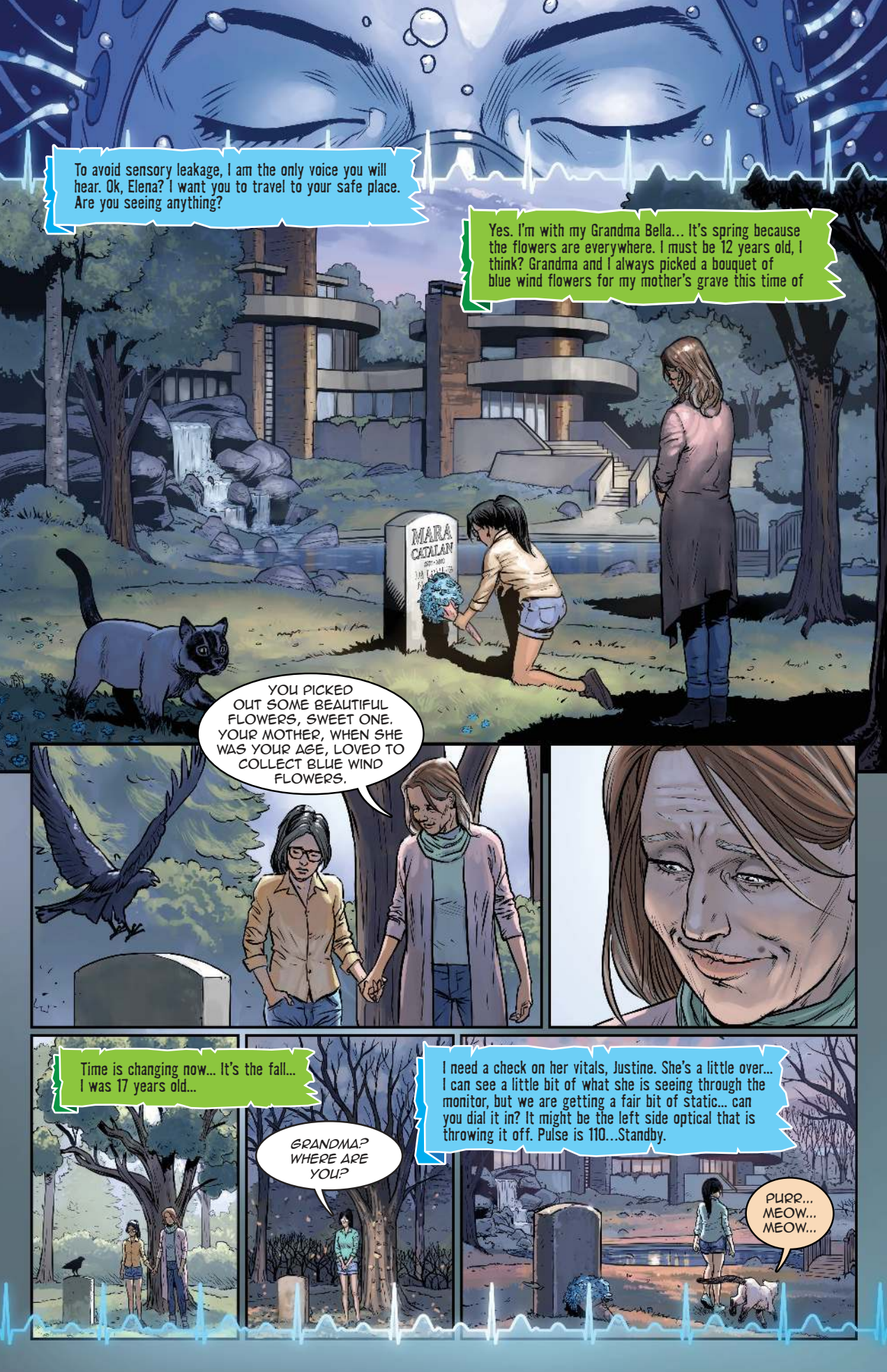
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CHAPTER 1

外而全主 龍中入龍 亞中今人 亞亞王
龍亞亞亞 以三金 亞龍亞 以多金 亞山 以亞亞亞 亞

Thus spake the Oracle, Isin Ada:
Dragon's head enchained in nether hall,
His tail, alas, entwines us all...



To avoid sensory leakage, I am the only voice you will hear. Ok, Elena? I want you to travel to your safe place. Are you seeing anything?

Yes. I'm with my Grandma Bella... It's spring because the flowers are everywhere. I must be 12 years old, I think? Grandma and I always picked a bouquet of blue wind flowers for my mother's grave this time of



YOU PICKED OUT SOME BEAUTIFUL FLOWERS, SWEET ONE. YOUR MOTHER, WHEN SHE WAS YOUR AGE, LOVED TO COLLECT BLUE WIND FLOWERS.



Time is changing now... It's the fall... I was 17 years old...

GRANDMA? WHERE ARE YOU?

I need a check on her vitals, Justine. She's a little over... I can see a little bit of what she is seeing through the monitor, but we are getting a fair bit of static... can you dial it in? It might be the left side optical that is throwing it off. Pulse is 110...Standby.

PURR... MEOW... MEOW...

Elena? I want you to breathe deeply and slow down, ok? Everything is fine. When did you say it was?

...It was in the fall of 2018, I think.

I didn't like going there... after the accident. I missed the kitty, Asim, though, so I went. Grandmother was gone...

HI, ELENA. DON'T YOU LOOK PRETTY TODAY.

I mean... her body was there, but her mind...

...was gone.

OOPS... SORRY.

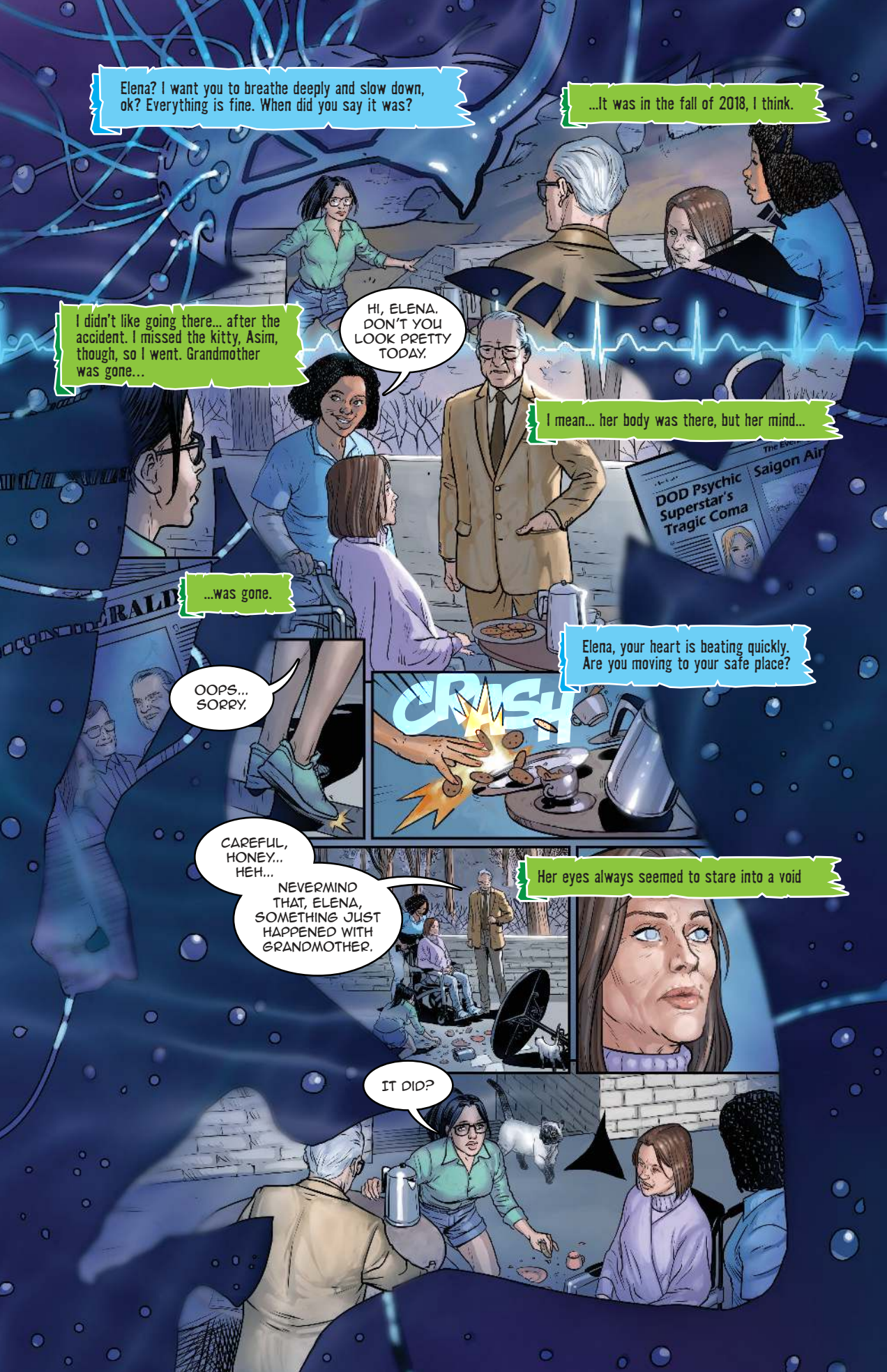
CAREFUL, HONEY... HEH...

NEVERMIND THAT, ELENA, SOMETHING JUST HAPPENED WITH GRANDMOTHER.

Elena, your heart is beating quickly. Are you moving to your safe place?

Her eyes always seemed to stare into a void

IT DID?





YES, SHE
UH...SHE JUST
SPOKE.

MEOW...

ARE YOU
SURE?

SHE
HASN'T TALKED
IN YEARS, SINCE
THE—SINCE ALL THE
EXPERIMENTS.

YES, I
KNOW—BUT SHE
JUST ASKED
FOR YOU.

BZZZ

Justine, I'm getting a faint visualization on the monitor.
Can you see if you can adjust the cortex connection a
little? We had better clarity last time...

GRANDMA BELLA,
IT'S ME! DID YOU
SAY SOMETH...?

FI...
FIND ME,
ELENA!

YOU
HAVE TO FIND
ME BEFORE IT'S
TOO LATE!

GASP...

BZZZ

Elena, can you hear me? We are here.
Can you feel me holding your hand?

ELENA! WHAT
HAPPENED?
DID SHE GRAB
YOU?



BZZZ

We're losing her again...
increase Midazolam drip...
we need to pull her back.

As Elena touched the water, she travelled to an unknown place in search of her grandmother, Sabella.

AMAZING...

She embraced her destiny just as her Grandma Sabella had done many years earlier.







GRRRR

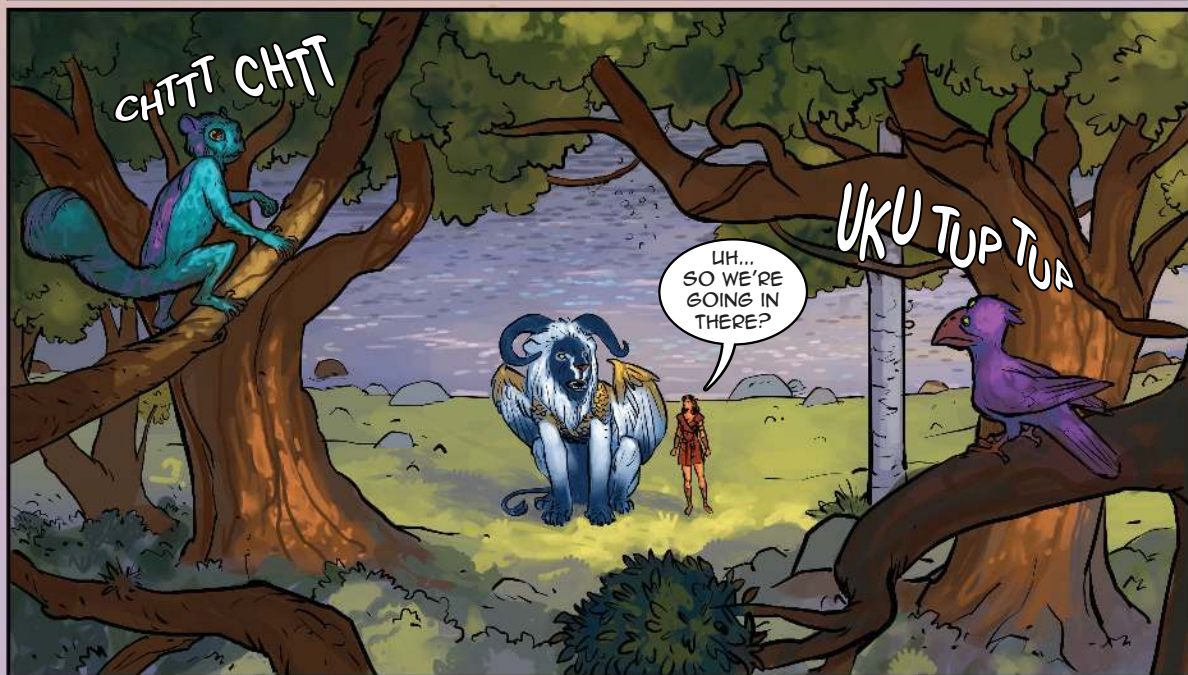
НСТННННСССС

КЕЕЕААГГГ

УААААА!!

THIS IS
TOO MUCH... I
DON'T UNDERSTAND.
WHAT IS THIS
PLACE?







AMAZING.
IT REALLY IS
SURREAL
HERE.



CHITT
CHTT



HMM...
SOME KIND
OF...



...HUT.
IT LOOKS
ABANDONED.



DOES
ANYONE LIVE
HERE? WHAT A
MESS.



RRUUGH

WAIT A
SECOND. WHY
ARE YOU TAKING
ME HERE, OF ALL
PLACES?

I'M
TRYING TO
FIND MY -
HEY!



THUMP



WHA?
HEY! WAIT!
WAIT!



OH
WONDERFUL,
NOW HE'S GONE.
JUST LIKE MY
LAST DATE.

IT
SEEMS LIKE
WHOEVER LIVED
HERE LEFT IN A
HURRY.



HUH,
THAT'S
A HUGE
BOOK.

My Elena, if you
should ever be so
unlucky as to come here...

COMPLETE
WITH A SECRET
COMPARTMENT?

I have faith Asim
will guide you to
this place. Take this...

WHAT?
GRANDMA BELLA?
SHE WAS **HERE**?!
WHAT IS THIS
THING?

It will serve you well in
your time of need.
I love you, sweet one.
-Grandma Bella

CRUNCH CRUNCH

GASP!



SOMEBODY
THERE? SHOW
YOURSELF... YOU
DO NOT TRICK ME.
I CAN SEE YOUR
FOOT...

**CRUNCH
CRUNCH**

WHAT?
NO YOU
CAN'T



YES,
I CAN...
IT'S RIGHT
THERE.

SWOOSH



I WILL
NOT HARM YOU,
SINNISTU.

UH... WHO
ARE YOU? WHERE
AM I? AND WHY ARE
YOU DRESSED LIKE
A GLADIATOR?

DO
YOU LIVE
HERE?



I AM CALLED UTU. YOU ARE IN THE HOLLOWLANDS, IN THE REGION OF TISH... BUT HOW DO YOU NOT KNOW THIS?



HAVE YOU LOST YOUR WAY?

I'M HONESTLY NOT SURE

PERHAPS, LIKE ME, YOU HAVE SUFFERED A HEAD WOUND AND FORGOTTEN?

YEAH, MAYBE I SHOULD JUST TAKE THIS BACK TO THE INSTITUTE



I DO NOT KNOW OF THIS INZ-TUT THAT YOU SPEAK ABOUT.

WHAT IS THAT WEAPON YOU WIELD?

STAY BACK!

I MEAN NO HARM, SINNISTU.



SORRY. I'M NOT USUALLY THIS JUMPY, BUT I JUST GOT MISTAKEN FOR A SNACK BY SOMETHING THAT LIVES IN THAT POND.

YOU ESCAPED A KRAINAR, SINNISTU?

A WHAT? MY NAME IS NOT SINNISTU, BY THE WAY.

IS THAT WHAT THAT WAS? WELL, IT WASN'T HAPPY TO SEE ME COME THROUGH.

A KRAINAR, A GUARDIAN OF THE DARK WATERS BETWEEN WORLDS

YOU TRAVELED THROUGH THE WATERS OF KUR?!



HUH...WHAT IS THIS THING? THE MARKINGS ON HERE SEEM FAMILIAR... ALMOST LIKE CUNEIFORM

SHH... SINNISTU!

CRUNG
CRUNCH



EXCUSE ME... MY NAME IS NOT SINNISTU.

...VISITORS, SINNISTU! SHHH...WE HAVE VISITORS

CRUNCH
CRUNCH



The Sightless, echoes from Elena's world, shambled out into the clearing toward an unknown destination.

THERE ARE 5000 MANY...

Always moving, always hungry but never aware...

KUK KUK

...of their often cruel shepherds...

CHAASHNOK

CRUNCH
CRUNCH



SNIFF SNIFF

THAT ONE IS HUGE! AND MEAN-LOOKING.



LOOK— THAT POOR MAN.



SHH... DO NOT INVOLVE YOURSELF!



IT LOOKS LIKE IT'S SUCKING OUT HIS SOUL! NO... YOU CAN'T JUST... I MUST STOP THIS!



STOP!

WHAT? WHAT AM I DOING?



UGH





THOSE?
THEY ARE SIGHTLESS -
WANDERERS IN
OUR REALM.

THE
OTHERS...OOF...ARE
SOUL CANNIBALS,
SHEPHERDS OF THE
SIGHTLESS...THEY ARE
HERDED TO THE
DARKLANDS
NEAR KUR.

HREK!

WHAT
ABOUT THAT
THING YOU JUST
KILLED?

THAT'S
HORRIBLE!
ER...LITU...I'M TRYING
TO FIND MY
GRANDMOTHER,
SHE LEFT ME
A MESSAGE.



IF ANYONE
KNOWS WHERE SHE IS,
IT WOULD BE THE ORACLE,
ISIN ADA. SHE LIVES EAST
OF HERE, JUST BEYOND THE
REACH OF THE
LUGAL.

SHE LIVES
EAST BEYOND THE
TOWER, OUTSIDE OF
THE GRASP OF THE
LUGAL, ATRUS
NUL.



THE WHO?
THE WHAT-
AL?

LUGAL IS HIS TITLE.
HIS NAME IS ATRUS NUL,
LORD AND EMPEROR OF THE
RIVERLANDS OF THE ATRAS
DOMINION. ALTHOUGH HIS EMPIRE
INCREASES WITH EVERY
PASSING YEAR. ONLY THE MISH
IN THE WEST RESIST HIM...BUT NOW
MOST ARE DEAD OR HAVE
FLED TO THE
FAR LANDS.

THIS LUGAL
SOUNDS PRETTY
BAD. WHY IS HE
SO FEARED?



SchaWink

THE LUGAL
ATRUS NUL IS A 20
FOOT TALL DEMI-GOD
WHO CRUSHES ALL WHO
DEFY HIS WILL. THERE
HAS BEEN WAR BETWEEN HIM
AND THE OTHER TITAN LORDS
FOR A THOUSAND YEARS. BAD?
IT IS A WONDER THAT THERE
REMAINS ANYTHING OF THE
HOLLOWLANDS. THE ORACLE
BARELY ESCAPED HIS
PRISONS.

LITU,
CAN YOU TAKE
ME TO HER? IF THIS
ORACLE CAN HELP ME
FIND MY GRANDMA BELLA
AND GET HOME, THEN I'M
READY TO LEAVE
RIGHT NOW.



NOT
WITHOUT THIS. I
DO NOT KNOW HOW
YOUR GRANDMOTHER
CAME BY SUCH A
WEAPON. BUT SOME-
THING TELLS ME THAT
YOU WILL NEED
IT.

THANKS.
IS THAT A
YES?



FOLLOW
ME,
SINNISTU.

MY
NAME IS
ELENA.



...95 now. Her pulse has normalized... I think we are back in business. No, she will not be able to hear me since she is under now... it's getting clearer...

ARE WE GOING TOWARD THAT?

YES, WE MUST GO TOWARD THAT, ELENA.

Holy smokes...you have to see this! We've never had this kind of clarity before. Get Dr. Kusarek down here!